



CASA Ethics Procedure for MSc/MRes Dissertations

Form A: Screening of Ethical Risk

Please only use **Acrobat Reader** to fill in this form. Use the 'Fill in Form' tools in Acrobat Reader. Do **not** use MacOS Preview.

Overview

There are different ways of addressing ethical considerations while conducting research at UCL. This form will help you define the level of ethical risk of your research and the corresponding ethical review path and requirements. ***You must complete this form and any follow-up step before you can begin with your research.***

Code of practice

Whether you are doing minimal, low or high-risk research, you should reflect on potential ethical issues arising from your research. If your research involves human participants, there are several principles or accepted ethical standards for conducting research in the UK:¹

- **Benefit and harm:** when conducting research involving human participants, you must balance out the benefits that your research could contribute to the society against the potential risks or harms for the participants involved in your research.
- **Informed consent:** you should provide clear information to your participants about their rights so that they can make an informed decision about whether they want to take part in your research. You should not induce, coerce or pressure them to participate and they should know that they can revert this consent.
- **Confidentiality:** you should ensure that the participation in your research remains confidential. Data should remain anonymous. The level of anonymity should reflect participants' consent.

There are other ethical principles and considerations that vary by field and type of research. Useful practical guidance can be found on the *Practising Ethics* website created by Prof Jane Rendell and Dr David Roberts at the Bartlett School of Architecture..²

Responsibility

As a student researcher, you are responsible for safeguarding research integrity, confidentiality, and the well-being of participants. Using this screening form, you will identify the level of ethical risk that your research entails. Depending on the outcome of the screening, you may need to seek and obtain ethical approval before you can begin with your research.

¹ See UCL's Research Ethics Policy, 'Guiding Ethical Principles', <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/research-innovation-services/training-and-resources/policies-and-guidance/ucl-research-ethics-policy#Guiding%20Ethical%20Principles>

² Consult the 'Practising ethics' project for a review of ethical principles relevant for research and practice in the built environment. 'Practising ethics', <https://www.practisingethics.org/>.

1. Personal details

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8th April 2026

2. Details of the research

2.1. Title or topic

A Flow-Based Definition of Gentrification: Analyzing Socio-Economic Displacement in London using Census Origin-Destination Data (2011–2021)

2.2. Project summary (max 250 words)

Provide a brief description **in plain English** of your project, detailing which methods you plan to use and what sources of information (e.g. databases, interviews) will you use and how you will access it (e.g. open data, how you will approach participants).

This project explores a dynamic way to measure gentrification in London by tracking the actual movement of people. Using quantitative spatial analysis in Python, I will identify "cascading flows", which is a process where affluent individuals move into a neighborhood, subsequently displacing lower-income residents to more deprived areas.

To achieve this, I will match neighborhood deprivation scores with migration paths to calculate a "Cascading Flow Index" and visualize these demographic shifts between 2011 and 2021 using Alluvial plots. The research relies entirely on secondary, anonymized, and publicly accessible open data. Sources include the 2011 and 2021 Census Origin-Destination data and ONS spatial boundaries accessed via the Nomis and Open Geography portals, alongside Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD) scores from GOV.UK.

2.3. Risk assessment

- ☒ Confirm that you are **not conducting fieldwork** (e.g. collection of data/observations carried out outside UCL premises).³ This can be within the UK or abroad.

– OR –

- ☐ Confirm that you are **planning to conduct fieldwork** and that you will complete the risk assessment form provided on Moodle in consultation with your supervisor.

³ Check UCL's Fieldwork Policy (<https://www.ucl.ac.uk/safety-services/policies/2023/nov/fieldwork>)

2.4. Selection of Ethics Committee

- ☒ Confirm that your research falls within the domain of **University Research** and, therefore, does not involve procedures that require external ethical review.

For more information about how to determine the domain of your research consult ['Which committee do I apply to?'](#).

– OR –

- ☐ Confirm that your research must be evaluated by one of the following external Research Ethics Committee: the NHS Research Ethics Committee, the Social Care Research Ethics Committee, the Ministry of Defence Research Ethics Committee or the Animal Welfare Ethics Review Board. If so, you must follow the ethics review procedure of the [respective institution](#).

If your research falls into the domain of NHS research, are you are planning to conduct fieldwork overseas?

☐ **Yes.** Please go to section 3 and complete the remainder of this form.

☐ **No.** Please go straight to section 6.

– OR –

- ☐ Confirm that your research **already has ethical approval** from a **UK** institution and state the name of the institution and the lead researcher below. Then go straight to section 6.

3. Screening for low risk

- | | YES | NO |
|--|--------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| 3.1. Will your research use data that are <u>not</u> already in the public domain or open to researchers? | ☐ | ☒ |

→ *Data in the public domain include Open Data, Census data, datasets provided through UCL Library or the UK Data Service.*

If you are using open data, please provide relevant URLs here:

https://www.nomisweb.co.uk/sources/census_2021_od
<https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/english-indices-of-deprivation-2019>

3.2. Will you collect, access, use, store or process data that are not anonymised <u>or</u>, if anonymised, may allow easy re-identification of individuals <u>or</u> may be classified as Personal Data? → <i>Personal Data comprise data pertaining to a person who could directly or indirectly be identified from that data, including data that you are collecting simply to contact your participants, such as names, residential addresses, email addresses, telephone number or IP addresses. Check UCL Guidance for processing personal data.</i>	☐	☒
3.3. Will your research involve observational methods where human participants will be recorded by means of video or audio recordings and can be identified?	☐	☒
3.4. Will your research involve the opinions of individuals <u>outside</u> the public arena? → <i>Individuals in the public arena include publicly appointed officials, artists, public figures.</i>	☐	☒
3.5. Will your research involve 'data scraping'? → <i>This would include web pages, forum posts, and APIs provided by third parties where the data scraped relates to human subjects.</i>	☐	☒

4. Screening for moderate or high risk		
	YES	NO
4.1. Will your research involve participants that could be identified as vulnerable (both directly or accidentally recruited), such as children, people with learning disabilities, asylum seekers or victims of crime?	☐	☒
4.2. Will your research involve participants access to whom requires the permission of a gatekeeper, such as adult professionals, family members or community leaders?	☐	☒
4.3. Will your research involve intrusive interventions, such as taking blood/DNA samples, administering drugs, performing imaging techniques or MRI scans?	☐	☒
4.4. Will your research involve the discussion of sensitive topics, such as terrorism, pornography, experiences of violence and abuse or criminal behaviour, or any other topics that may be particularly sensitive due to specific cultural or political characteristics of the group you are researching?	☐	☒

4.5.	Will your research present a significant risk of harm (beyond harm encountered in normal life) to the rights and well-being of participants or/and of a member of the research team? → <i>This may include physical, emotional psychological harm (e.g. distress, humiliation or anxiety) or reputational, legal or financial harm.</i>	☐	☒
4.6.	Will your research involve a risk of disclosure of confidential information, such as information concerning participants' involvement in illegal activities?	☐	☒
4.7.	Will your research involve an element of deception or covert methods of observation or data collection whereby identifiable human participants are included without their knowledge, fully informed consent cannot be obtained, or only limited consent is sought?	☐	☒
4.8.	Do you intend to offer monetary compensation or incentives (other than a copy of your report or refreshments during the interview) to recruit participants?	☐	☒
4.9.	Will your research involve participants that are your own family, friends, colleagues, or clients that would make them obliged (due to their relationship with you) to reveal information that they would otherwise not disclose?	☐	☒
4.10.	Is your research commissioned by the military or falls under a European Union (or other) security programme?	☐	☒

5. Screening outcome

Before selecting the screening outcome, is there any additional information that you think the reviewer might need to confirm the level of risk? **This is optional.**

No.

See next page to select the situation that applies to you.

- ☒ You answered NO to all questions in sections 3 and 4.

This means that your research poses **minimal** ethical risk and does not require further ethical review.

– OR –

- ☐ You answered YES to one or more questions in section 3 and NO to all questions in section 4.

This means your research poses **low** ethical risk and must be assessed by the Departmental Ethics Committee.

– OR –

- ☐ You answered YES to one or more questions in section 4.

This means that your research poses a **high** ethical risk and must be assessed by UCL Research Ethics Committee (REC).

6. Please submit your form to Moodle.

If the ethical risk of your research is:

- **Minimal/exempt** or **already approved by a UK institution**: Await confirmation on Moodle. You may proceed with data collection when confirmed.
- **Low** or **High**: You must apply for ethics using the low-risk route. Discuss details with your supervisor and then for ethical approval via: [UCL Research Ethics Service](#) » Applicant login. Log in using your UCL credentials, create a new project and choose UCL: Master's student project. Complete the form.
- In the scope of **an external ethics committee** (i.e. you came here straight from section 2.4): Continue with that committee's procedure in consultation with your supervisor.